as Dharmaraksa and Kasyapa Matanga were noted in China around the beginning of the Common Era, followed by a procession of artists and teachers. Later, Indian migrations were also noted in Thailand, Vietnam and the Malay Peninsula.[41] When Fa-Hien, a Buddhist pilgrim from China, arrived in India in the 5th century CE, he returned by sailing from Tamralipti in Bengal to South East Asia and observed the flourishing Brahmanas in Indo-China.[42]

There is also a particular mention of the emigration and settlement of a large troupe of 12,000 Indian musicians to Iran in the 5th century CE, on invitation by Persian king Bahram Gor.[43] A Hindu physician by the name of Manka has been noted in Baghdad in the late 8th century CE, translating books from Sanskrit to Arabic.[44] Such translations were important for the transfer of ancient Indian knowledge in astronomy, mathematics, medicine and other fields to the Arabic world. Indian settlements were also noted in West Asia where they were valued as accountants, artisans, gunners and cooks.[45] The 14th century Moroccan traveller Ibn Battuta, who now has a Bollywood music track in his honour, found Indians in troops and military establishments of the Byzantine Empire. But the most famous early Indian diasporic link comes from the Romas or Gypsies found across Europe today as relatively poor nomads and who trace their origins, with genetic evidence, to not just south Asia, but the low-ranking castes and indigenous tribes of north-west India.[46] The date of their dispersal has been placed in the late ancient period even as the exact causes for the outmigration remain shrouded in mystery.

Ancient India thus witnessed different types of migrations from outside and within, all contributing towards greater diversity and a better understanding of regional geography. This was manifested through vivid descriptions as expressed in poet Kalidasa's *Meghaduta,* or 'Cloud Messenger', and later by the purposeful locations of Hindu monasteries in four different corners of the subcontinent—Dwarka (west), Puri (east), Sringeri (south) and Badrinath (north).[47] Migrants—pilgrims, pastoralists, merchants, monks, soldiers and colonizers—were slowly connecting